himself from the area and recorded local memories of how Dost Mohammad's arrival was greeted in Tagab:

> The first to come forward was the triumphant warrior from Parwan
> Wise and knowing, Rajab Khan was his name
>
> 'You are the Amir and we are your servants,' he said,
> 'We bow our heads before your command
>
> These unworthy hovels of ours, this land of rock and thistle
> You have made worthy by your presence.'
>
> At the Amir's order, those courageous rebels
> Rode their horses through the mountainous lands
>
> Nowhere was there a moment's respite or hesitation
> Dreading in their hearts a Firangi attack
>
> For fear that *he* would beat them to it –
> That wretched Burnes at Charikar[93]

There followed weeks of guerrilla warfare, with Dost Mohammad making surprise attacks on government outposts and inflicting casualties, but lacking the strength to take on the massed forces of the Company. Meanwhile General Sale systematically laid waste to rebel-held villages, destroyed the rebels' trees and crops, and besieged the rebel-held forts around the Koh Daman, while Burnes tried to bribe the Kohistan chiefs to betray and hand over the Amir. By the end of September, Burnes had managed to pry the Mir Wali and his Uzbeks away from Dost Mohammad, leaving the Amir with just a few hundred Kohistani supporters; but still he eluded capture. 'The fighting between the Amir and the English lasted two months,' wrote Mirza 'Ata. 'There were 13 clashes and skirmishes, and never in that time did the English even glimpse the lovely face of victory. Rather it was the Amir who carried off the polo-ball of victory from the field of battle. Eventually the English abandoned their search and straggled back into Charikar half-dead, leaving much of their supplies and equipment behind.'

According to Mohan Lal, much of this fighting and destruction was anyway ill judged and unnecessary: the Kohistan chiefs had made it clear that they were willing to call a halt to their insurgency and only wished for the promises made to them the previous year to be honoured. One